

The Calm Lab Playbook

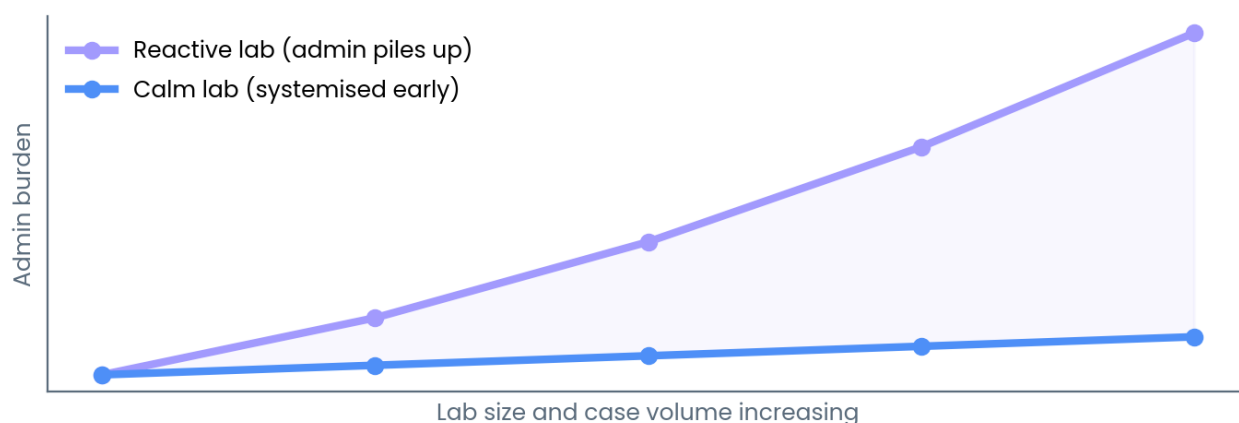
Five principles the calmest labs in the room had in common. Straight from owners who scaled through the chaos and out the other side.



Matt Everatt sharing how he scaled S4S, at our May roundtable.

At our roundtable we noticed something: the owners who seemed calm were not the smallest, they were the ones who systemised before the admin outgrew them. The gap looks like this.

Admin load as the lab grows



Illustrative. Reactive labs add admin faster than they add capacity.

01 Automate before you think you need to

The owners who struggled most were the ones who waited. The advice was unanimous: set up your systems early, even with one or two scanners, because adding more later is easy. Waiting until you are overwhelmed is the hard way.

"You want to automate early. Even if you've only got two, now's the time. What you don't want is to realise you're already overburdened."

Steve, Managing Director, Nexus Dental

02 Keep skilled technicians on skilled work

Every calm lab protected its technicians' time fiercely. The moment a trained technician is booking cases in and chasing invoices, the lab is paying craft wages for admin work.

"If you're a skilled technician doing administrative tasks, you are killing your business. A skilled technician should only be doing skilled technician work, nothing else."

Steve, Managing Director, Nexus Dental

03 Measure the admin you cannot see

Lost time hides as "it was just a slow morning." The calm labs counted it. Once you know how many hours go to intake before real work starts, you can fix it.

"Labs don't openly talk about it. They just put it down to, it took me a long time to get these booked in. But it's a real cost."

Matt Everatt, former founder of S4S Dental Laboratory

04 Connect the tools, do not just add more

Scanners, LMS, DSO portals and accounting are each great alone. The problem is the gaps between them. Calm labs reduced the number of disconnected systems instead of piling on new ones.

"All of them in isolation are fantastic. But in isolation means a lot of admin. At one point we had more admin staff than technicians."

Matt Everatt, former founder of S4S Dental Laboratory

05 Aim for one place to work

The end state every owner described was the same: one point where every case lands, anyone can see its status, and the portal it came from stops mattering. Work runs in parallel, not in a queue.

"I want one ingestion point. Everything else is a waste of our time. I want nobody to think about portals anymore."

Steve, Managing Director, Nexus Dental

See a calm lab in action

Book a 20 minute demo. We show you what one connected workflow looks like, loaded with your own scanners.

The Lab Admin Audit

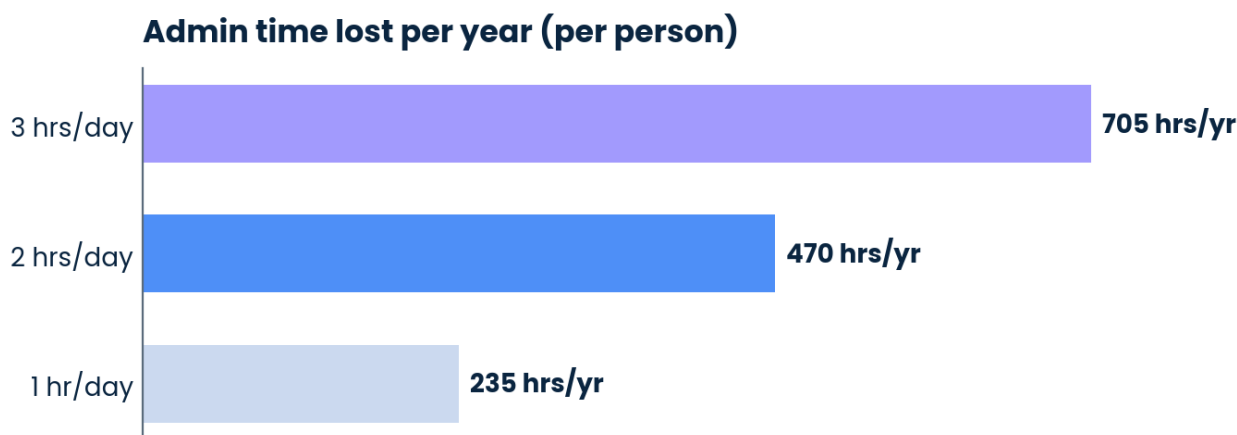
A 10 minute self-check to find out what admin is really costing your lab, in hours and in pounds. Built from what 35 UK lab owners told us actually slows them down.



35 UK lab owners at our May roundtable.

Why this matters

At our roundtable, the most consistent theme was this: labs almost never measure the time lost to admin. It gets written off as a bad day. As Matt Everatt, who built one of the UK's largest independent labs, put it: "Eight o'clock in the morning, how many hours is it taking you before you even start?"



Illustrative, based on a 47 week working year, one person.

Score each section honestly. Totals at the end, then run the revenue check.

1 — Your systems

How many separate portals or systems do you log into to receive and track cases? (1 to 2 = 0, 3 to 4 = 2, 5+ = 4) _ _ _ _

Do scanners and DSO portals feed into one place, or do you check each separately? (one place = 0, separate = 3) _ _ _ _

When a case comes in, is it logged automatically or rekeyed by hand? (auto = 0, manual = 3) _ _ _ _

2 — Your time

How long does case intake and booking-in take before technical work starts each morning? (under 1 hr = 0, 1 to 2 hrs = 2, 2+ hrs = 4) _ _ _ _

How often does someone ask "where did that scan come from?" or "did we bill that?" (rarely = 0, weekly = 2, daily = 3) _ _ _ _

At month end, how manual is invoice reconciliation? (automated = 0, partly = 2, fully manual = 4) _ _ _ _

3 — Your team

Are skilled technicians doing administrative tasks? (no = 0, sometimes = 2, often = 4) _ _ _ _

What is your ratio of admin staff to technicians as you grow? (stable = 0, rising = 3) _ _ _ _

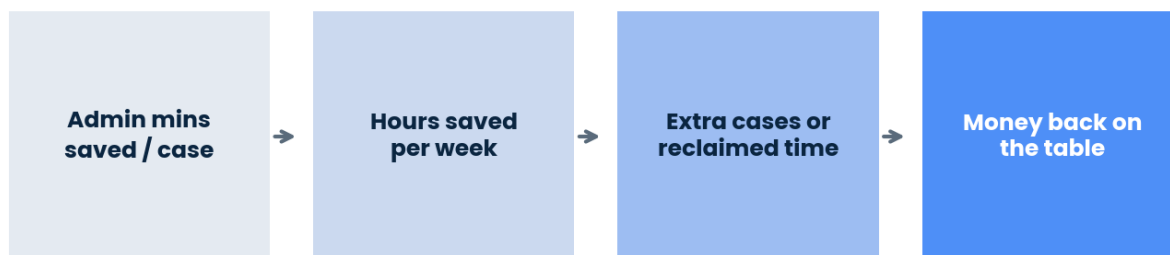
If your busiest admin person was off for a week, would case flow hold up? (yes = 0, no = 3) ----

Your score

Score	What it means
0 to 8	A calm lab. You systemised early. Protect it as you scale.
9 to 18	The frog is warming. Admin is creeping up faster than you have noticed.
19+	You are in the boiling water. Admin is costing you cases and technician time.

What it's costing you: the revenue check

Lost admin time is not just hours, it is money left on the table. Here are two ways to see it. Both use round, conservative numbers so you can sanity check them against your own.



ILLUSTRATIVE EXAMPLE

Angle 1 — The cost of time spent on admin

	Example	Your lab
Cases per week	200	-----
Admin minutes saved per case	3 min	-----
Hours saved per week	10 hrs	-----
Loaded staff cost per hour	£18	-----
Weeks worked per year	47	-----
Annual value of that time	£ 8,460	£ -----

Formula: cases/week × mins saved ÷ 60 × hourly cost × weeks = annual value.

ILLUSTRATIVE EXAMPLE

Angle 2 — The revenue from cases that time could win back

	Example	Your lab
Hours saved per week	10 hrs	-----
Avg hours of work per case	4 hrs	-----
Extra cases possible per week	2.5	-----
Average case value	£90	-----
Weeks worked per year	47	-----
Annual revenue opportunity	£ 10,575	£ -----

These are illustrative figures, not a guarantee. Your numbers depend on your lab. Use the blanks to run your own.

Want us to run your real numbers with you?

Book a 20 minute demo. We load your actual scanners and show you where the time, and the money, is going.